

PLEDGE Curriculum Plan

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Context + Rationale

Firearm-related injuries are the leading cause of death among youth in the United States. Despite the urgency of this issue, firearm safety education is often absent from school curricula or is framed in partisan terms. The **PLEDGE** Curriculum seeks to fill this gap by providing a non-partisan, research-based, and community-driven curriculum that empowers students to actively participate in creating safer communities. Ultimately, PLEDGE aims to focus on childhood education to reduce firearm injury and promote firearm safety.

The PLEDGE student curriculum is aimed towards high school students (grades 9-12) and their parents or guardians. Recognizing that different schools and communities have varying resources and constraints, the curriculum is designed with flexible implementation models. Whether facilitated by teachers, school nurses, counselors, or community members, the core principles remain the same: fostering critical thinking, promoting responsible safety practices, and encouraging community engagement. The facilitator module (“train the trainer”) aims to ensure that all facilitators selected by a school to teach its students feel fully prepared to teach and lead nuanced, thoughtful discussions.

Educational Philosophy and Design Principles

Our curriculum is designed to emphasize a collaborative, interdisciplinary approach to firearm safety, viewing the students as critical thinkers and active participants in creating a safer world. PLEDGE is an acronym that stands for:

PLEDGE values:

- P** - Prevent firearm injury through education and awareness.
- L** - Learn about responsible firearm safety practices.
- E** - Educate others to promote a culture of safety.
- D** - Deter firearm-related injury by fostering responsible behavior.
- G** - Guard against unauthorized access to firearms through secure storage.
- E** - Empower students to create safer communities.

The PLEDGE curriculum is grounded in the belief that students are not just learners but also key contributors to building safer communities. Drawing on Nel Noddings’ idea that schools must play a central role in helping students become morally responsible adults, we aim to engage students in meaningful conversations about safety, responsibility, and community care. The curriculum emphasizes the role of the students in a border community and encourages students to take moral responsibility within their communities. The curriculum is designed to be flexible and inclusive, encouraging educators to adapt it to their school’s unique needs.

We believe students learn best when the material feels relevant to their lives. That's why PLEDGE centers student voices and encourages them to explore personal and community perspectives around safety. Our approach is rooted in John Dewey's philosophy of experiential learning, in which students learn best through active engagement in real-world problems.

The PLEDGE curriculum was designed with a participatory and trauma-informed approach.

Participatory design

The framing of firearm safety as a problem that requires human-centered and participatory design will enable students to be invested in the solution process and engage with the material in a way that feels empowering and action-oriented. Participatory design enables “participants to realize that there are alternative choices, that they can negotiate what they care about in those choices, and that they can influence how the choices are pursued,” meaning that students can be a core part of envisioning a safer future (Van der Velde et al., 2021). The structure of the curriculum is such that students create their own meaning through scaffolded activities to create a portrait of individual and collective community safety where different viewpoints can be expressed and represented.

Key learner question: What matters most to you about your current experiences in school? How might you imagine a better future than what exists today in regards to firearm safety through individual and community action?

Trauma-informed approach

Given the potentially traumatic nature of this content and students' previous life experiences that may have been shaped by trauma, we believe that designing curriculum with a trauma-informed approach is essential to ensuring it meets students where they are and fosters a sense of safety and support. Research highlights that, with high rates of youth exposure to traumatic events and the significant impact of those experiences on academic achievement, schools represent “a natural system in which to help prevent and reduce the adverse effects of trauma and more effectively engage students in the learning process” (Chafouleas et al., 2016). To support this, our curriculum will integrate trauma-informed principles that promote “safety, trustworthiness, and transparency; peer support; collaboration and mutuality; empowerment, voice, and choice; and attention to cultural, historical, and gender considerations”, ensuring that students feel supported while engaging in meaningful discussions about firearm safety (Substance Abuse and Mental Health Services Administration, 2014).

Key learner questions: How do you support others that have had traumatic experiences? How can you create a safe and supportive environment for discussing difficult topics like firearm safety?

Student Curriculum

Overall student outcomes

Essential Questions (EQs) and Essential Understandings (EUs) for the entire PLEDGE curriculum for high school students are below, and additionally crafted for each lesson.

Goals

1 Outcome 1: Firearm safety is a shared community responsibility.

Essential question How might we harness the unique perspectives of our community to frame firearm safety as a collective responsibility?

Enduring understanding

- Safety is a shared responsibility in our community.
- We can respect diverse perspectives while also promoting safety.
- Community safety requires individuals to take informed, responsible actions to prevent harm.

2 Outcome 2: Students develop knowledge and skills for responsible decision making.

Essential questions How can we make our communities safer when firearms are present? What are the principles of firearm safety, and how can we teach and share them?

Enduring understanding

- There are specific behaviors people can engage in to prevent firearm-related injuries and improve community safety.
- Understanding how reducing access to firearms during mental health crises is important to community safety.
- Safe and responsible behaviors come from knowledge, reflection, and intentional action.
- We can resolve conflicts without violence.

Lesson 1: Community Safety and Conflict Resolution (1 hr 10 mins)

Goals

- Introduce PLEDGE, individual and communities' perspectives around safety
- Discuss ways to resolve conflicts without violence

Enduring understanding

- Safety is a shared responsibility in our community.
- How we interact with firearms impacts our safety.
- We can respect diverse perspectives in our community while also promoting safety.
- We can resolve conflicts using our words and not violence.

Essential question How can we use the unique perspectives within our community to help everyone see firearm safety as something we all care about and work on together?

Activities

1 Pre-survey and Welcome (15 min)

What is it? An online pre-survey to understand student self-perceived knowledge, attitudes, beliefs, and skills related to firearm safety, collected for program evaluation purposes. Following the survey, the facilitator opens with an opening question to have students begin thinking about community safety.

How does it work? Students can use mobile phones or computers to answer the pre-survey on Qualtrics (surveying software; Stanford's version can store high risk data securely). Facilitators can either wait until all students have finished before introducing the opening question, or the opening question can be displayed on the board for students to think about while others complete their survey. The opening question can be answered in large group discussion or on a post-it note so students can submit their answers anonymously.

Sample opening questions:

Example questions:

- How do you define safety? What words come to mind?
- How do you define "firearm safety"?
- How do you define community?

2 Intro to PLEDGE firearm safety + debrief (10 min)

Who am I? Facilitator introduces their position and their frame of reference, i.e. teacher, school counselor, or law enforcement, etc.

What is it? Acknowledge potential emotional difficulty with the topic and ways to manage those emotions, as well as local resources for those who want to discuss more after the lesson. Allow for students who have had past experiences related to this topic to choose to participate or not and offer alternate activity for those who opt out. Debrief anything from the survey that came up.

How does it work? Facilitators have the opportunity to discuss the emotions that students shared in their poll responses and how emotions will continue to be a part of the discussion. This is an opportunity to set the tone for how the facilitator will actively listen and respect student voice. Facilitators will also allow students to opt-out of this activity if they choose based on their past experiences and provide alternate activity if they choose to go opt out.

Sample opening to set the tone:

Before we begin, we want to create a respectful and open environment for discussion. Here are our community guidelines during PLEDGE:

- **Listen respectfully** to others' experiences and viewpoints.
- **Acknowledge different perspectives**—people come from a wide range of backgrounds and beliefs.
- **Ask questions thoughtfully** and with the intent to understand, not to challenge.
- **Maintain privacy**—what is shared in the group stays in the group.

What We Will Discuss: During the PLEDGE program, we will focus on topics related to **community safety and well-being**, including:

- Community safety and responsibility
- Conflict resolution and de-escalation
- Firearm safety and secure firearm storage
- Suicide prevention and recognizing mental health crises
- How to access trusted adults and local resources for help

What We Will NOT Discuss: This program does **not** cover or debate politically or personally charged issues, such as:

- Whether individuals or families **should or should not own firearms**
- **Political views** related to firearms
- **Personal opinions** on gun rights or laws

Our focus is solely on **keeping everyone safe** and **knowing what to do to prevent harm** in our homes and communities.

3 Perspectives Activity (20 min)

What is it? An activity for students to understand how their classmates define community, and orient students to thinking about the intersection of personal and community perspectives oriented around safety.

How does it work? The facilitator will ask the students to stand in a line at one end of their learning space and ask students to take a step forward if a statement that the facilitator reads aloud applies to them. Everyone should observe the movement of the line with each statement. The facilitator should establish that no one must move. There can be statements that students are unsure of or uncomfortable responding to, so reassure the room that they are not obligated to move but encouraged to participate.

Following this observation, students would sit back down and be guided through a selection process of perspectives from a list (such as this [sample list](#)) to help them think about what they

care about most as individuals as it pertains to safety. They will first select 5 of their favorites, then cut down to 2. Students will do a Think-Pair-Share with their top two. Students will share their top two principles with Post-Its on all on the board to create a visual representation of what the classroom community feels is most important for community safety. Facilitator then leads a guided discussion about how these principles show up in the school community.

Detailed Content:

PLEDGE PERSPECTIVES ACTIVITY

Accountability	Inclusion	Responsibility
Awareness	Integrity	Self-Discipline
Bravery	Justice	Support
Collaboration	Kindness	Trust
Compassion	Mindfulness	Understanding
Community	Nonviolence	Vigilance
Courage	Preparedness	Well-being
Empathy	Prevention	Write your own: _____
Honesty	Respect	_____

Perspectives Activity Introduction (5 mins):

Context Setting: Introduce the idea that our perspectives guide both personal actions and community behaviors. Emphasize that today's focus is on identifying the perspectives that contribute to a safe environment and identifying ways to resolve conflicts without violence.

Focus on Safety: We will center our discussion around shared perspectives—particularly those that foster a culture of safety. We will also discuss ways to resolve conflicts without violence and promote community safety.

Trauma-Informed: Facilitators should acknowledge that students may come to this topic with a wide range of experiences related to safety, including firearm safety. Some may find the discussion activating or emotionally challenging. Students should be informed that they may opt out of the discussion at any point and instead complete an alternative activity (as pre-approved by the teacher or facilitator). Students may also choose to participate if they feel it helps them process or reflect on their experiences. Either choice should be framed as valid and supported.

Purpose: Briefly outline that the activity will help connect individual perspectives to how we, as a community, can shape our approach to firearm safety.

Community Line Activity (10 mins)

Have students line up at the end of the learning space. Read each statement and encourage students who identify with that statement to take a step forward. Everyone should observe the movement of the line with each statement. The facilitator should establish that no one has to move. There can be statements that students are unsure of or uncomfortable responding to, so reassure the room that they are not obligated to move but encouraged to participate.

Facilitator shares that how we understand words like community, environment, and safety affects how we view our responsibility to keep our communities safe.

List of Statements

There are lots of types of communities that you may belong to and help make up your identity.

1. If you identify as being a part of the (insert school) community, then please take a step forward.
2. If you belong to a band or orchestra community, then please take a step forward.
3. If you identify as being a part of a faith-based community, then please take a step forward.
4. If you identify as belonging to an athletic or sports community, then please take a step forward.
5. If you belong to a gaming community, then please take a step forward.
6. If you identify as being a part of an online community, then please take a step forward.
7. If you generally feel a sense of responsibility for keeping your community (or communities) safe, please step forward.

After the activity, facilitators can engage students in a conversation about what they learned from the experience.

Sample script: Thank you all for participating in the Community Line activity. It was great to see how many different communities you belong to and how that shapes your identity. Each step forward represents not just your connection to those communities, but also the unique perspectives you bring to our discussion about safety and responsibility.

Now let's take a moment to reflect on what we just experienced. Think about the movement of the line and how it changed with each statement.

Select potential debrief questions: What surprised you about the responses of your classmates? How do different perspectives on community and safety shape our responsibilities toward one another? In what ways can we work together to enhance safety in our communities?

Potential Closing: As we move forward, let's consider how we can work together to enhance safety in our communities. I encourage you to share your thoughts and insights as we dive deeper into this conversation.

Individual Perspectives Selection (5 min)

Provide students with the curated list of perspectives. Ask them to read through and reflect on which perspectives resonate with their personal understanding of safety and community well-being. These perspectives could be from a pre-selected list chosen by the facilitator or [this sample list could be used](#), which has been curated to be about community safety.

Step 1: Select **five perspectives** from the list that they feel are important to them right now. Students could add their own ideas as well if they do not find any from the list that resonate. Emphasize that these perspectives are not the *only* ones that matter to the student, but are what they view as important in the present moment. Students may decide other perspectives are more important at a different time or in a different context.

Step 2: Narrow down these five to their **top two perspectives** that they believe most strongly influence their sense of safety at this moment. Instruct students to jot down a brief note for each of their top two choices explaining why these are important to them. Again, reiterate that these are not the only two perspectives that a student can find important, but the two that they are most drawn to in this moment for the context of safety.

Some optional sentence stems that can be shared with students are:

- When I think about _____, I feel _____.
- _____ is important to me because _____.

- _____ motivates me to _____.
- My commitment to _____ comes from _____.

Think-Pair-Share (3 min)

Have students pair up and share their chosen top two perspectives.

Reflection questions: Why do you think these perspectives are essential for your personal safety and for our community? How do these perspectives influence your views on how we should approach firearm safety? Can you recall a moment when one of these perspectives contributed to a positive or safe experience for you or someone you know? **Tip:** Encourage each pair to explore both similarities and differences in their choices.

Group Sharing & Visual Mapping (3 min)

Invite pairs (or volunteers) to share their top two perspectives with the whole class. As perspectives are shared, write each on a Post-It note and place them on a board. This visual collage represents the “community perspectives” emerging from the group. Prompt the group to notice recurring themes and unique perspectives.

Potential debrief questions: What might these perspectives say about our diverse perspectives on safety? How can the ideas we identified (e.g., respect, responsibility, trust) shape our approach to discussions about firearm safety? In what ways can these perspectives help us focus on proactive safety and well-being? What practical steps can we take as a community to ensure that these shared perspectives guide our actions, especially around topics like firearm safety?

4 Conflict Resolution Activity (20 min)

What is this? Introduction of content/takeaways through hands-on small group discussion

How does it work? Students are assigned a scenario with key questions to discuss in small groups. The room should be divided into 4 different groups as the discussion questions are different for each group. Facilitators prompt students to talk about what you would do in these scenarios. After this, the facilitator would have each group share out their discussion questions and answers to allow the entire class to benefit from each small group’s discussion.

Content: Students will be divided into four small groups to complete the scenario, with each group being assigned a different set of questions. Each group should read through and discuss the scenario (10 mins). Then, the facilitator will ask each group to share their discussion content, so all students will have learned about each characters’ perspectives by the end (10 mins).

Trauma-Informed: Facilitators should acknowledge that students may come to these topics with a wide range of experiences related to conflict between peers. Some may find the discussion activating or emotionally challenging. Students should be informed that they may opt out of the discussion at any point and instead complete an alternative activity (as pre-approved

by the teacher or facilitator). Students may also choose to participate if they feel it helps them process or reflect on their experiences. Either choice should be framed as valid and supported.

See [Appendix below for case and discussion questions](#).

5 Parking Lot Questions (5 min)

How does it work? Students have an individual exit ticket that they fill out.

Content:

Which perspective that you selected today resonates most with you, and why? (Consider how it helps you feel safe or contributes to a positive community environment.)

What tip will you use for resolving a conflict between you or your classmates?

What question or concern do you still have about the topics we discussed today?

If anything we talked about today made you feel upset? Y/N

Would you like to talk to someone for support, please check this box. ☐

We will keep it private and help connect you with counseling support.

Assessment

- Pre-poll survey
- Exit ticket for the day with 'parking lot questions'
- Observation of discussion - individual student engagement (e.g., participation, reasoning, and perspectives shared) and group dynamics (e.g., trends in discussion, key points of consensus or debate, and shifts in understanding), which will help assess how students are processing and applying concepts from the curriculum.

Lesson 2: Firearm Safety and Personal Pledge (1 hr 10 mins)

Goals

- Learn about firearm safety behaviors and problem solving
- Identify a personal action to promote community safety

Enduring understanding

- There are specific behaviors that people can engage in to prevent firearm-related injuries and improve community safety.
- Understanding how reducing access to firearms during mental health crises is important to community safety.
- Empower students to take ownership of their role in promoting firearm safety and creating safer communities.

Essential questions How can we make our communities safer when firearms are present? What are the “rules” of firearm safety and how can we teach and share them? What role will I play in making our community safer?

Activities

1 ‘Parking Lot Questions’ Warm-Up (5 min)

What is this? A facilitator will go over selected answers to student generated questions from the last session from the exit ticket submissions as a way to provide some continuity between modules.

If no appropriate student-generated questions are available, consider warming up with one or two of the sample questions, based on facilitator knowledge of the group (background knowledge, maturity level, group dynamics). Remind students there are no “right” answers, just thoughtful conversations. Sample questions: What’s one perspective you remember the group identifying last time that felt important for building safety in your school or community? Did anything from our last session stick with you or come to mind outside the classroom? Did anyone encounter a situation where they could use their conflict resolution skills?

2 Case Studies / Scenarios (30 min)

What is this? Introduction of content/takeaways through hands-on small group discussion

How does it work? Students are assigned a scenario with key questions to discuss in small groups. We prompt students to talk about what you would do in a variety of scenarios. After this, each group presents their scenario and key takeaways for 5 minutes each (15 minutes total).

Content: Students will be divided into three groups to complete one of the three scenarios. Each group should read through and discuss the scenario, and are encouraged to use the suggested resources as they discuss (15 mins). Then, each group will share their case scenario and discussion for 5 minutes each with the entire class, so all students will have learned the take-home message of each scenario by the end (15 mins).

Trauma-Informed: Facilitators should acknowledge that students may come to these topics with a wide range of experiences related to firearm safety and suicide. Some may find the discussion activating or emotionally challenging. Students should be informed that they may opt out of the discussion at any point and instead complete an alternative activity (as pre-approved by the teacher or facilitator). Students may also choose to participate if they feel it helps them process or reflect on their experiences. Either choice should be framed as valid and supported.

- [Secret in the backpack](#)
 - Child brings firearm to school
 - In addition to the resources highlighted in the case discussion, facilitators are suggested to also identify and discuss school-specific protocols for students to be aware of in this situation

- [Secure Storage: Not a Game Anymore](#)
 - Secure firearm storage and what to do when encountering an unsecured firearm
- [The text message \(suicide threat\)](#)
 - Suicide prevention and limiting access to firearms in times of mental health crisis
 - In addition to the resources highlighted in the case discussion, facilitators are suggested to also identify and discuss mental health resources available in the school or district

3 Group discussion of EQ and firearm safety basics (15 min)

What is this? Information sharing and reflection

How does it work? Facilitator shares a factual presentation with real-life examples of how different experts/roles resolved these challenges along with best practices related to **PLEDGE** content. This is with the goal to help students answer the scenario better.

Content:

- [10 minutes mini-lecture for Wisconsin](#)
 - Epidemiology of firearm injuries
 - What to do if you come across a firearm: stop, don't touch, leave, tell a trusted adult
 - Assume all firearms are loaded, hands off a trigger, don't point a gun towards people
 - Toy or "imitation" firearms can appear very similar to real firearm
 - Secure firearm storage best practices
 - Secure firearm storage devices
 - Suicide prevention and limiting access to lethal means in times of mental health crisis
 - Bystander actions: recognize potential harm, choose to respond, take action through delegating (enlist help from adult), direct action (take action yourself), or distract (create a distraction that will diffuse the situation).

4 Personal Action Plan (10 min)

What is this? How will you apply what you have learned to make our communities safer?

How does it work? Students create a personal action plan by reflecting on what they learned during the module. What did they learn about firearm safety? How can these lessons be applied to their lives?

Context Setting: The concluding activity transitions to personal application, having students identify their own role in fostering firearm and community safety, and responsible decision-making.

Passive vs. active participants: Reflect on the perspectives exercise and reinforce the idea that every individual has a role to play in actively preventing firearm-related incidents and fostering community safety.

Purpose: The Personal Action Plan is designed to help students internalize and apply their learning by developing practical strategies for real-world situations.

Trauma-Informed: Facilitators should acknowledge that students may come to this topic with a wide range of experiences related to safety, including firearm safety. Some may find the discussion activating or emotionally challenging. Students should be informed that they may opt out of the discussion at any point and instead complete an alternative activity (as pre-approved by the teacher or facilitator). Students may also choose to participate if they feel it helps them process or reflect on their experiences. Either choice should be framed as valid and supported.

Activity:

- Write your personal action plan for yourself. This will not be shared with the class.
- Propose 3 sentences of actions or reactions toward different scenarios.

Sample content:

- Personal Safety Commitment, i.e. What will I do _____?
- Prompt fill-ins
 - If I find a firearm in the house, I will _____.
 - If I see my friend with a firearm, I will _____.
 - If my friend wants to learn more about firearm safety, I will _____.
 - To help my family and friends stay safe, I will _____.
 - If someone close to me is struggling emotionally, I will _____.

3 Think-Pair-Share (3 min)

Have students pair up and share their thoughts about what they might consider to include in their personal action plan.

Reflection questions: Given what we learned, what are some things that we can do? Who might you want to share your personal action plan with (e.g. family members, community members)? What resources do you need to ensure you can achieve your personal action plan?

Tip: Encourage each pair to explore both similarities and differences in their choices.

5 Reflections and Close (10 min)

- Repeat Qualtrics survey to check learning over the two modules
- Exit ticket
- Share **PLEDGE** library of resources.
- Congratulate the class and celebrate completion of the **PLEDGE** program!

How does it work? Students repeat the Qualtrics survey to assess their learning. Following that, they complete an individual exit ticket that they fill out and give to the facilitator. As they wrap up, facilitators should share additional PLEDGE resources and celebrate the class's completion of the PLEDGE program.

Content:

Qualtrics Survey linked here

Exit Ticket:

What is one thing that you learned today that you will use going forward?

What is one action you will do to make our community safer? Share one of the items from your personal action plan.

If anything we talked about today made you feel upset or like you want to talk to someone, please check this box. ☐

We will keep it private and help connect you with counseling support.

Resources and Wrap Up:

Share **PLEDGE** library of resources. Congratulate the class and celebrate completion of the **PLEDGE** program!

Assessment

- Post baseline poll
- Exit ticket
- Observation of scenario discussion (i.e. individual and group engagement)

Optional Additional Activities

Goals

- Empower students to take ownership of their role in promoting firearm safety and creating safer communities through community-oriented action.
- Reinforce the **PLEDGE** principles.

Enduring understanding

- Community safety is a shared responsibility that requires individual action.
- Individual perspectives can drive meaningful change at home, in school, and in the broader community.
- Safe and responsible behaviors come from knowledge, reflection, and intentional action.

Essential questions How can we, as a community, help improve safety? How can I use what I've learned to make my community safer? How can I inspire others to prioritize responsible behaviors around firearm safety?

Activities

1 Community Action Plan (35 min)

What is this and how does it work? What kind of Public Awareness Campaign about firearm safety can you create as a group?

Content:

- Design posters, infographics, song, poem, or short story promoting firearm safety and community safety. Focus on key messages like secure storage, firearm safety rules, and responsible behavior. Ensure your project reflects your collective learning journey and the importance of firearm safety.
- Create a 2-3 minute group presentation about firearm safety, safe firearm storage, and mental health awareness.

Trauma-Informed: Facilitators should acknowledge that students may come to this topic with a wide range of experiences related to safety, including firearm safety. Some may find the discussion activating or emotionally challenging. Students should be informed that they may opt out of the discussion at any point and instead complete an alternative activity (as pre-approved by the teacher or facilitator). Students may also choose to participate if they feel it helps them process or reflect on their experiences. Either choice should be framed as valid and supported.

Details:

1 Introduction and activity framing (5 min)

Context Setting: Introduce the idea of shifting focus from understanding towards action, and empowering students to take an active role in promoting firearm safety within their homes, schools, and communities.

Awareness vs. Action: Explain that having awareness of strategies and knowledge that reinforce safety practices fosters a sense of agency, helping students understand that they have a role in reducing firearm-related risks.

Purpose: Briefly outline that the activities will emphasize empowerment, personal responsibility and community engagement.

Trauma-Informed: Facilitators should acknowledge that students may come to this topic with a wide range of experiences related to safety, including firearm safety. Some may find the discussion activating or emotionally challenging. Students should be informed that they may opt out of the discussion at any point and instead complete an alternative activity (as pre-approved by the teacher or facilitator). Students may also choose to participate if they feel it helps them process or reflect on their experiences. Either choice should be framed as valid and supported.

Review with students that we just talked about the kind of outcomes we want to achieve, and ask, “*What are some ways we can achieve these outcomes?*” **Example answers:** Teach our friends about firearm safety, be proactive if I see a firearm.

Follow-up question: *How can we impact or teach the community about firearm safety?*

Example answers: Community events, posters, public awareness campaigns.

2 Group Activity (20 min)

For each of the groups, we will create an artifact for a public awareness campaign that we will hold in our classroom. The artifact will be displayed in the classroom.

Example ideas for artifacts:

- Posters
- Infographics
- Songs
- Poems
- Short story

For this artifact, you will need to include:

- At most 3 key messages: *what do you want others to know about firearm safety?*
- Answer: *why is learning about firearm safety important?*

Be ready to give a 2-3 min presentation to talk about your artifact.

3 Group presentations: (10 min)

Groups present their artifacts. During the group presentation time, students will fill out a graphic organizer as a meta-analysis for students to capture key learnings and serve as an informal assessment.

Community Action Plan Graphic Organizer			
	Key takeaways about Gun Safety	Why should we learn about Gun Safety	Any Questions / Comments?
Group 1			
Group 2			
Group 3			
Group 4			

Assessment

- Community Action Plan creation and share-out
- Class participation and reflection

Appendix

Conflict Resolution Case Study

9th Grade: The Football Game Face-Off

The vibe at school has been off all week. Alex and Jake, close friends since sixth grade, aren't talking. It started when they both caught feelings for the same girl, Mia. At first, it was just awkward. But then Jake confronted Alex in front of their friends, accusing him of trying to steal Mia. Alex pushed back, saying it wasn't like that. Besides, Alex said, "Mia makes her own choices." The argument got loud. People stopped and watched. Now, it feels like the whole school knows, and the tension between them is building fast.

As the week progressed, Jake vented his frustration to his friend Jenny, who encouraged Jake to stand up for himself to avoid future disrespect. He posted a picture of Alex on social media with the caption "Watch out for snakes." Alex went live that night and said Jake is "really bold online, but can't keep that same energy at school." Mark, who knows Alex has a temper and has helped calm him down in the past, texted Alex after seeing his post but Alex didn't respond.

By Thursday, the situation was very heated. Jake's cousins (who don't even attend their school) started joining the argument online and posting aggressive comments. It seemed everyone was taking sides.

By Friday afternoon, everyone is excited about going to the football game. But people are also overhearing Jake and Alex arguing again near the lockers. Everyone also knows that Jake has been saying he was going to bring his crew of cousins to the game tonight.

Their mutual friends are starting to worry about how this situation is going to go down at the game tonight.

9th Grade Discussion Questions

Group A:

1. What could potentially happen if this situation does not de-escalate?
2. Look back at the full list of perspectives from the Perspectives Activity. What is guiding Jake's actions throughout his conflict with Alex?
3. If you were in Jake's position, what might you have done differently throughout the week?
4. If you were in Jake's position, how would you want your friends to support you? What could your friends do to help you feel comfortable discussing your conflict rather than acting physically?
5. In what ways has social media contributed to the ongoing tension between Alex and Jake? How would you handle a conflict with a friend online?

Group B:

1. What could potentially happen if this situation does not de-escalate?
2. If you were Jake's friend Jenny, how do you feel about the current conflict?
3. If you were Jenny, what actions could you take to help de-escalate the situation? Specifically, how could you directly act, delegate, or distract in this situation? See Closing Reflection for more information.
4. What perspective (from the Perspectives Activity) would be driving your actions?
5. In what ways has social media contributed to the ongoing tension between Alex and Jake? How would you handle a conflict with a friend online?

Group C:

1. What could potentially happen if this situation does not de-escalate?
2. If you were in Mia's position, how would you feel about the current conflict between Alex and Jake?
3. If you were in Mia's position, what might you do to help de-escalate the situation? Specifically, how could you directly act, delegate, or distract in this situation? See Closing Reflection for more information.
4. If you were in Mia's position, how would you want your friends to support you?
5. In challenging situations like these, what people or resources at your school or in your community might you seek support from?

Group D:

1. What could potentially happen if this situation does not de-escalate?
2. If you were Alex's friend Mark, how do you feel about the current conflict?
3. If you were Mark, what actions could you take to help de-escalate the situation? Specifically, how could you directly act, delegate, or distract in this situation? See Closing Reflection for more information.
4. What perspective (from the Perspectives Activity) would be driving your actions?
5. In challenging situations like these, what people or resources at your school or in your community might you seek support from?

Closing Reflection

Conflict can build over time, and it's important to recognize how misunderstandings can escalate, especially in the age of social media. We can use our different perspectives to help guide our actions to promote community safety. As community members, we can each take action to de-escalate conflicts between peers. Together, we can create a culture of accountability to step up and act when we see situations that can escalate into violence.

Here are three steps we can all take to de-escalate conflicts as bystanders:¹

1. **Recognize potential harm:** identify high-risk situations that can lead to harm.

- a. In this scenario, the intense confrontation between Alex and Jake, amplified by social media and the involvement of Jake's cousins, indicates a potential escalation toward violence.
2. **Choose to respond:** assess the situation and choose how you will respond.
 - a. In this scenario, each individual in Alex and Jake's circles must decide how they can safely intervene without escalating the situation.
3. **Take action:** What step will you take to intervene proactively?
 - a. There are three ways to take action in the moment, and only intervene if it is safe for you to do so.
 - i. **Direct action:** take action yourself by confronting the situation to de-escalate the conflict.
 1. E.g. When you see Alex and Jake arguing in the hallway, you pull Alex out of the argument and walk away down the hallway with him.
 2. E.g. Privately reach out to Jake as a friend and share your perspective, emphasizing communication rather than confrontation.
 - ii. **Delegate:** enlist help from someone else - reach out to a trusted adult, faculty, or staff member.
 1. E.g. You reach out to the school counselor to share your concerns about the escalating conflict between Alex and Jake.
 - iii. **Distract:** create a distraction that will diffuse the situation and allow the conflict to cool down.
 1. E.g. You see Alex and Jake arguing in the hallway. You spill your water bottle on the floor near them and say, "Ugh, what a mess! Can someone help me grab some paper towels?"

If we all take action in ways that we feel comfortable and safe doing so, we can create a culture where peaceful resolution of conflicts is valued. If you see the situation escalating, consider ways that you can safely directly act, delegate, or distract. Don't hesitate to seek help from trusted adults, like teachers or school staff, or other resources at your school. They can help mediate conflicts or provide guidance to ensure everyone stays safe. Remember, promoting peace and understanding can make a significant difference in your school community.

[1Adapted from Green Dot Bystander Intervention Training Program](#)

11th Grade: Homecoming Dance Face-Off

The vibe at school has been off all week. Noah and Danny, close friends since sixth grade, aren't talking. It started when they both caught feelings for the same girl, Zoe, and Danny asked Zoe to the upcoming Homecoming Dance. Word got around the grade pretty fast that Danny and Zoe would be going to the dance together, and that Noah still had feelings for her. At first, it was just awkward. But then Noah confronted Danny in front of their friends, accusing him of

trying to steal Zoe. Danny pushed back, saying it wasn't like that. Besides, Danny said, "Zoe makes her own choices." The argument got loud. People stopped and watched. Now, it feels like the whole school knows, and the tension between them is building fast.

As the week progressed, Noah vented his frustration to his friend Jenny, who encouraged Noah to stand up for himself to avoid future disrespect. He posted a picture of Danny on social media with the caption "Watch out for snakes." Danny went live that night and said Noah is "really bold online, but can't keep that same energy at school." Mark, who knows Danny has a temper and has helped calm him down in the past, texted Danny after seeing his post but Danny didn't respond.

By Thursday, the situation was very heated. Danny's cousins, Theo and Johnny, (who don't even attend their school) started joining the argument online and posting aggressive comments. The cousins have been close since childhood, and they have always been very protective of their little "bro" Danny.

By Friday afternoon, everyone is excited about going to the dance. But people are also overhearing Noah and Danny arguing again near the lockers. Everyone also knows that Danny has been saying he was going to bring his crew of cousins to the dance tonight.

Their friends, including Jenny and Mark, are starting to worry about how this situation is going to go down at the dance.

11th Grade Discussion Questions:

11th Grade Discussion Questions

Group A:

1. Look back at the full list of perspectives from the Perspectives Activity. What is guiding Noah's actions throughout his conflict with Danny?
2. If you were in Noah's position, what might you have done differently throughout the week?
3. If you were in Noah's position, how would you want your friends to support you? What could your friends do to help you feel comfortable discussing your conflict rather than acting physically?
4. What are the potential consequences of the conflict escalating at the dance? Discuss the implications for Noah, his friendships, social circles, and the broader school community. How might this conflict affect his reputation and relationships with others?
5. In what ways has social media contributed to the ongoing tension between Noah and Danny? Discuss the implications of online communication versus face-to-face interactions. How can misunderstandings be exacerbated online? How can you handle a conflict with a friend online?

Group B:

1. If you were Noah's friend Jenny, how do you feel about the current conflict? What elements of this conflict make you think that the conflict could escalate into potential harm?
2. If you were Jenny, what actions could you take to help de-escalate the situation? Specifically, how could you directly act, delegate, or distract in this situation? See Closing Reflection for more information.
3. What perspective (from the Perspectives Activity) would be driving your actions?
4. In what ways has social media contributed to the ongoing tension between Noah and Danny? Discuss the implications of online communication versus face-to-face interactions. How can misunderstandings be exacerbated online? How can you handle a conflict with a friend online?

Group C:

1. If you were in Zoe's position, how would you feel about the current conflict between Noah and Danny? What elements of this conflict make you think that the conflict could escalate into potential harm?
2. If you were in Zoe's position, what might you do to help de-escalate the situation? Specifically, how could you directly act, delegate, or distract in this situation? See Closing Reflection for more information.
3. What perspective (from the Perspectives Activity) would be driving your actions?
4. If you were in Zoe's position, how would you want your friends to support you?
5. In challenging situations like these, what people or resources at your school or in your community might you seek support from?

Group D:

1. If you were Danny's friend Mark, how do you feel about the current conflict? What elements of this conflict make you think that the conflict could escalate into potential harm?
2. If you were Mark, what actions could you take to help de-escalate the situation? Specifically, how could you directly act, delegate, or distract in this situation? See Closing Reflection for more information.
3. What perspective (from the Perspectives Activity) would be driving your actions?
4. In challenging situations like these, what people or resources at your school or in your community might you seek support from?

Closing Reflection

Conflict can build over time, and it's important to recognize how misunderstandings can escalate, especially in the age of social media. We can use our different perspectives to help guide our actions to promote community safety. As community members, we can each take action to de-escalate conflicts between peers. Together, we can create a culture of accountability to step up and act when we see situations that can escalate into violence.

Here are three steps we can all take to de-escalate conflicts as bystanders:¹

4. **Recognize potential harm:** identify high-risk situations that can lead to harm.
 - a. In this scenario, the intense confrontation between Noah and Danny, amplified by social media and the involvement of Danny's cousins, indicates a potential escalation toward violence.
5. **Choose to respond:** assess the situation and choose how you will respond.
 - a. In this scenario, each individual in Noah and Danny's circles must decide how they can safely intervene without escalating the situation.
6. **Take action:** What step will you take to intervene proactively?
 - a. There are three ways to take action in the moment, and only intervene if it is safe for you to do so.
 - i. **Direct action:** take action yourself by confronting the situation to de-escalate the conflict.
 1. E.g. When you see Noah and Danny arguing in the hallway, you pull Noah out of the argument and walk away down the hallway with him.
 2. E.g. Privately reach out to Noah as a friend and share your perspective, emphasizing communication rather than confrontation.
 - ii. **Delegate:** enlist help from someone else - reach out to a trusted adult, faculty, or staff member.
 1. E.g. You reach out to the school counselor to share your concerns about the escalating conflict between Noah and Danny.
 - iii. **Distract:** create a distraction that will diffuse the situation and allow the conflict to cool down.
 1. E.g. You see Noah and Danny arguing in the hallway. You spill your water bottle on the floor near them and say, "Ugh, what a mess! Can someone help me grab some paper towels?"

If we all take action in ways that we feel comfortable and safe doing so, we can create a culture where peaceful resolution of conflicts is valued. If you see the situation escalating, consider ways that you can safely directly act, delegate, or distract. Don't hesitate to seek help from trusted adults, like teachers or school staff, or other resources at your school. They can help mediate conflicts or provide guidance to ensure everyone stays safe. Remember, promoting peace and understanding can make a significant difference in your school community.

¹Adapted from [*Green Dot Bystander Intervention Training Program*](#)

Firearm Safety Case Studies

9th Grade: Secret in the Backpack

You're walking home from school with your friend and neighbor Leo, and things feel a little off. He's quieter than usual, glancing around nervously. After a while, Leo stops, pulls you aside, and says, "I need to tell you something, but you have to promise not to freak out." Before you

can respond, he unzips his backpack just enough for you to catch a glimpse of a handgun inside.

“I brought it for protection,” he says. “Don’t worry, I’m not going to hurt anyone. But you know how Jack has been messing with me lately. If he tries to mess with me again, I wanna be prepared.” Leo looks scared, not aggressive.

You’ve never been in a situation like this before. What do you do next?

9th Grade Discussion Questions

1. What thoughts are going through your mind in this situation? What feelings are you experiencing?
2. What are the potential risks of keeping this a secret vs. telling someone? Why is safety more important than keeping a secret?
3. Who could you talk to that might help keep both Leo and your school safe?
4. What systems or supports are in place at your school to handle situations like this?

Closing Reflection

If you ever found yourself in a situation like this, it would be completely normal to feel scared, confused, or unsure of what to do. You might want to protect your friend, but also feel the weight of keeping something this serious a secret. It’s important to remember that safety—for you, your friend, and everyone around you—comes first. Even if your friend says they don’t plan to hurt anyone, bringing a gun to school is dangerous and against the law, and things can go wrong quickly.

In Wisconsin, it is prohibited for people to have a firearm in a school zone, with a few exceptions for law enforcement ([State of Wisconsin](#)). Under state law, possessing a firearm in school zones is a [Class I felony](#), which can result in up to 3.5 years in prison and/or a fine of up to \$10,000. Shooting a firearm in school zones is Class G felony, which can result in up to 10 years in prison and/or a fine of \$25,000. Possible consequences from schools for students who bring a firearm to a school zone include suspension, expulsion, and/or referral to law enforcement. This also applies to other dangerous weapons including lookalike weapons (e.g. Airsoft guns).

As a bystander, consider the steps to intervene:

1. **Recognize potential harm:** identify high-risk situations that can lead to harm.
 - a. A firearm on a school campus can lead to serious injuries or death, and is a high risk situation for potential harm.
2. **Choose to respond:** assess the situation and choose how you will respond.
3. **Take action:** What step will you take to intervene proactively? In the Conflict Resolution scenario, we learned about three ways for a bystander to take action: Direct Action, Delegate, and Distract.

- a. In this situation, given the severe potential harm and seriousness of the situation, the most appropriate first action is to **Delegate**: enlist help from a trusted adult, faculty, or staff member.

Speaking up doesn't mean you're betraying your friend—it means you care enough to get them the help they need before something terrible happens. You're not alone in figuring it out. Trusted adults like teachers, counselors, and school staff are there to support you. Choosing to act with courage and care can make a real difference—not just in keeping your school safe, but in helping your friend stay safe too.

11th Grade: Secret in the Backpack

You're walking home from school with your friend and neighbor Jason, and things feel a little off. He's quieter than usual, glancing around nervously. After a while, Jason stops, pulls you aside, and says, "I need to tell you something, but you have to promise not to freak out." Before you can respond, he unzips his backpack just enough for you to catch a glimpse of a handgun inside.

"I brought it for protection," he says. "Don't worry, I'm not going to hurt anyone. But you know how Owen has been messing with me lately. If he tries to mess with me again, I wanna be prepared." Jason looks scared, not aggressive.

You've never been in a situation like this before. What do you do next?

11th Grade Discussion Questions

1. What thoughts are going through your mind in this situation? What feelings are you experiencing?
2. What are the potential risks of keeping this a secret vs. telling someone? Why is safety more important than keeping a secret? How can you rebuild trust with Jason if it is broken by reporting the situation?
3. Who could you talk to that might help keep both your friend and your school safe?
4. What systems or supports are in place at your school to handle situations like this?
5. What conflict resolution strategies should Jason have considered instead of bringing a weapon to school? What are some ways to address bullying or harassment without violence?
6. Think about how Jason's environments (at school and at home) may have influenced his decision to bring a gun for protection. What factors in the environment may have influenced his decision? How can understanding these factors help in addressing the root causes of this conflict?

Closing Reflection

If you ever found yourself in a situation like this, it would be completely normal to feel scared, confused, or unsure of what to do. You might want to protect your friend, but also feel the weight of keeping something this serious a secret. It's important to remember that safety—for you, your friend, and everyone around you—comes first. Even if your friend says they don't plan to hurt anyone, bringing a gun to school is dangerous and against the law, and things can go wrong quickly.

In Wisconsin, it is prohibited for people to have a firearm in a school zone, with a few exceptions for law enforcement ([State of Wisconsin](#)). Under state law, possessing a firearm in school zones is a [Class I felony](#), which can result in up to 3.5 years in prison and/or a fine of up to \$10,000. Shooting a firearm in school zones is [Class G felony](#), which can result in up to 10 years in prison and/or a fine of \$25,000. Possible consequences from schools for students who bring a firearm to a school zone include suspension, expulsion, and/or referral to law enforcement. This also applies to other dangerous weapons including lookalike weapons (e.g. Airsoft guns).

As a bystander, consider the steps to intervene:

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 - a. A firearm on a school campus can lead to serious injuries or death, and is a high risk situation for potential harm.
5. **Choose to respond:** assess the situation and choose how you will respond.
6. **Take action:** What step will you take to intervene proactively? In the Conflict Resolution scenario, we learned about three ways for a bystander to take action: Direct Action, Delegate, and Distract.
 - a. In this situation, given the severe potential harm and seriousness of the situation, the most appropriate first action is to **Delegate**: enlist help from a trusted adult, faculty, or staff member.

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9th Grade: Secure Storage

One afternoon, 10-year-old Dylan is hanging out at a friend's house after school. The two of them are playing a video game in the living room when Dylan's friend Luke suddenly says, "Hey, want to see something cool?" He leads Dylan down the hall, into his parents' bedroom, and opens the closet.

Behind a stack of shoeboxes, Luke reaches for something—a gun.

“It’s my dad’s,” he says, holding it up. “I think it’s loaded. It’s like the one I use in the game.”

Dylan’s heart starts pounding. His parents have always told him that guns are dangerous, and he remembers hearing about kids getting hurt by them. But Luke seems relaxed, even excited. He’s not pointing the gun at anyone, just holding it.

This moment raises some big questions. How should guns be stored? How can we prevent children from accessing guns? What should the next steps be?

9th Grade Discussion Questions

1. What would you advise Dylan to do in this situation?
2. What was unsafe about this situation?
3. What could the adults in Dylan and Luke’s life do in this situation to make this safer?
4. What is the ideal way to securely store a firearm?

Closing Reflection

If you were advising Jordan, you could share that even if a friend seems calm or playful, a gun is never a toy. The safest thing to do in a moment like this is to step away, avoid touching the gun, and tell a trusted adult as soon as possible. Taking action can save a life.

Guns should always be stored locked, unloaded, and out of reach of children. Securely storing guns prevents unauthorized access and enhances public safety. Firearms should be secured unloaded in a locked container, such as a gun safe or lockbox, and/or securely locked with a cable or trigger lock, to prevent unauthorized access. Ammunition should be stored separately from firearms and kept in a locked container to ensure additional safety. In Wisconsin, a firearm owner can be [criminally charged](#) if their improperly stored firearm is accessed and used by a child under 14 without permission, which can lead to fines and imprisonment. Counties and cities may have additional laws related to firearms and their storage.

There are many types of firearm safety devices that can be used to securely store firearms:

- Gun Safe
 - A heavy-duty safe that stores firearms inside
 - Various types with different locking mechanisms (key, biometric fingerprint, combination, etc.)
 - Most secure and reliable— designed to completely prevent unintentional handling of firearms
 - Higher cost
- Lockbox
 - A small, portable, lockable container
 - Moderate security – designed to completely prevent unintentional handling of firearms, though less secure than gun safe



- Lower cost
- Cable Lock
 - A cable is threaded through the firearm to block operation
 - Less secure— not designed to entirely prevent access to the firearm
 - Lower cost
- Trigger Lock
 - Prevents the trigger from being pulled
 - Less secure— not designed to entirely prevent access to the firearm
 - Lower cost



Remember: No storage method is effective unless consistently used.

Secure storage best practices:

- Always lock firearms with an appropriate firearm safety device even when storing in a locked container
- Keep ammunition in a separate, locked container
- Regularly check and maintain storage devices to ensure that they are functioning correctly.
- Educate all household members about the importance of firearm safety and proper storage practices.

Keeping firearms and ammunition locked has been associated with a lower risk of firearm injuries for children and teens in homes where firearms are stored ([Grossman 2005](#)). Speaking up about secure storage doesn't mean you're against anyone—it means you're taking responsibility to protect yourself, your friends, and your community. Your actions can make a significant difference in ensuring a safe environment for everyone.

Here are additional resources you can use to learn more about secure storage:

- [SchoolSafety.gov](#) Secure Storage Fact Sheet:
- https://www.ojp.gov/sites/g/files/xyckuh241/files/media/document/safe_storage_fact_sheet.pdf
- California Office of the Attorney General Firearm Safety <https://oag.ca.gov/firearms/tips#owners%20responsibilities>
- University of Michigan Institute for Firearm Injury Prevention Family Resources <https://firearminjury.umich.edu/family-safe-storage/>

11th Grade: Secure Storage

One afternoon, 10-year-old Jordan is hanging out at a friend's house after school. The two of them are playing a video game in the living room when Jordan's friend Alex suddenly says,

“Hey, want to see something cool?” He leads Jordan down the hall, into his parents’ bedroom, and opens the closet.

Behind a stack of shoeboxes, Alex reaches for something—a gun.

“It’s my dad’s,” he says, holding it up. “I think it’s loaded. It’s like the one I use in the game.”

Jordan’s heart starts pounding. His parents have always told him that guns are dangerous, and he remembers hearing about kids getting hurt by them. But Alex seems relaxed, even excited. He’s not pointing the gun at anyone, just holding it.

This moment raises some big questions. How should guns be stored? How can we prevent children from accessing guns? What should the next steps be?

11th Grade Discussion Questions

1. What would you advise Jordan to do in this situation?
2. What was unsafe about this situation?
3. What could the adults in Jordan and Alex’s life done in this situation to make this safer? How could the gun have been stored more safely?
4. What is the ideal way to securely store a firearm?
5. If you were the parent or guardian of Jordan, how would you handle the situation after learning about it? What about if you were the parent or guardian of Alex? Discuss the steps you would take to ensure both children understand the seriousness of the situation and to prevent future incidents.

Closing Reflection

If you were advising Jordan, you could share that even if a friend seems calm or playful, a gun is never a toy. The safest thing to do in a moment like this is to step away, avoid touching the gun, and tell a trusted adult as soon as possible. Taking action can save a life.

Guns should always be stored locked, unloaded, and out of reach of children. Securely storing guns prevents unauthorized access and enhances public safety. Firearms should be secured unloaded in a locked container, such as a gun safe or lockbox, and/or securely locked with a cable or trigger lock, to prevent unauthorized access. Ammunition should be stored separately from firearms and kept in a locked container to ensure additional safety. In Wisconsin, a firearm owner can be [criminally charged](#) if their improperly stored firearm is accessed and used by a child under 14 without permission, which can lead to fines and imprisonment. Counties and cities may have additional laws related to firearms and their storage.

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- Regularly check and maintain storage devices to ensure that they are functioning correctly.
- Educate all household members about the importance of gun safety and proper storage practices.

Keeping firearms and ammunition locked has been associated with a lower risk of firearm injuries for children and teens in homes where guns are stored ([Grossman 2005](#)). Speaking up about secure storage doesn't mean you're against anyone—it means you're taking responsibility to protect yourself, your friends, and your community. Your actions can make a significant difference in ensuring a safe environment for everyone.

Here are additional resources you can use to learn more about secure storage:

- [SchoolSafety.gov](https://www.schoolsafety.gov/sites/g/files/xyckuh241/files/media/document/safe_storage_fact_sheet.pdf) Secure Storage Fact Sheet: https://www.ojp.gov/sites/g/files/xyckuh241/files/media/document/safe_storage_fact_sheet.pdf

- California Office of the Attorney General Firearm Safety <https://oag.ca.gov/firearms/tips#owners%20responsibilities>
- University of Michigan Institute for Firearm Injury Prevention Family Resources <https://firearminjury.umich.edu/family-safe-storage/>

9th Grade: The Text Message (Suicide Threat)

It's late in the evening, and you're scrolling through messages with your best friend. The conversation has been all over the place—complaints about school, memes, plans for the weekend. You're half paying attention when a new message pops up.

"I'm done with being stressed. I just can't do this anymore. Peacing out tonight. Got my dad's pistol and everything. Sending love."

For a moment, the words don't register. Then your stomach drops. You look at the message again and wonder if this is literal or an exaggerated comment. He seems pretty serious.

9th Grade Discussion Questions

1. What details in the message stand out to you?
2. How will you respond?
3. Who will you reach out to?
4. If you respond directly to your friend, what might you say?
5. What are the consequences of not reacting to this message?
6. How do you feel when reading this text? Discuss how you might seek support for yourself after encountering a distressing situation.

Closing Reflection

Reading a message like that from a friend can be really scary. You might feel frozen or unsure if it's serious. But when someone talks about ending their life, it's always something to take seriously. If you or someone you know is having thoughts of hurting themselves, there are professional organizations like the [American Academy of Pediatrics](#) and the [American Foundation for Suicide Prevention](#) that recommends [the following](#):

"If you are worried about yourself or a friend, talk with a trusted adult. They can help you find the right support, such as going to see a pediatrician, primary care clinician, [school counselors], or mental health professional. They have tools to help. If they ask about thoughts of suicide, it is not to offend or cause harm but to keep you safe. When talking with a professional, be open and honest to be sure they have the information needed to help. Ask questions to make sure you understand and are okay with their suggestions.

Starting a conversation with a friend can be awkward. It's important not to judge or make assumptions. Sharing mental health struggles takes a lot of bravery and vulnerability. Try to be

supportive: be there for them, and listen to what they have to say. Pay attention to your own limits when helping friends, and try not to feel bad about needing a break. If you don't take care of yourself, you will not be able to provide emotional support to others."

It's important to know that suicide is the third leading cause of death among teenagers, and about 50% of teen suicides involve a firearm ([American Foundation for Suicide Prevention](#)). Guns make suicide attempts much more likely to be fatal (85-90%). Limiting access to firearms during mental health crises can help save lives. Research shows that when someone can't access their chosen way to commit suicide, most people won't switch to another method in the moment ([Daigle 2005](#)). That's why it's critical to take any warning signs seriously and limit access to lethal methods. Additionally, there are laws to help protect people with mental health crises ([State of California](#)).

If you ever find yourself in this situation, please remember: **you are not responsible for your friend's choices**. Whatever happens, **it is not your fault**. You didn't cause it, and you're not responsible for fixing it alone. Speaking up could save a life—and that's one of the most powerful things you can do for a friend.

Here are additional resources you can use:

- Crisis Text Line: Text TALK to 741741 for free, 24/7 support via text
- 988 Suicide & Crisis Hotline 24/7 Call or text 988 in a mental health crisis or visit 988lifeline.org
- [Never a Bother](#) (California Dept of Health's Office of Suicide Prevention)
- [Safe Storage Protects Children](#) (Wisconsin Office of Children's Mental Health)
- American Foundation for Suicide Prevention:
 - LGBTQ crisis support resources: <https://afsp.org/lgbtq-crisis-and-support-resources/>
 - Risk Factors and warning signs: <https://afsp.org/risk-factors-protective-factors-and-warning-signs/>
- Trans Lifeline Peer support. Call 877-565-8860 or visit translifeline.org
- HealthyChildren.org by American Academy of Pediatrics Information on supporting resilience and mental health in families
- Society for the Prevention of Teen Suicide: sptsusa.org

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For a moment, the words don't register. Then your stomach drops. You look at the message again and wonder if this is literal or an exaggerated comment. He seems pretty serious.

11th Grade Discussion Questions

1. What details in the message stand out to you?
2. How will you respond?
3. Who will you reach out to?
4. If you respond directly to your friend, what might you say?
5. What are the consequences of not reacting to this message?
6. How do you feel when reading this text? Discuss how you might seek support for yourself after encountering a distressing situation.
7. Mental health issues can be difficult for anyone to talk about. How might we make it easier for students to seek help or talk about their feelings?

Closing Reflection

Reading a message like that from a friend can be really scary. You might feel frozen or unsure if it's serious. But when someone talks about ending their life, it's always something to take seriously. If you or someone you know is having thoughts of hurting themselves, there are professional organizations like the [American Academy of Pediatrics](#) and the [American Foundation for Suicide Prevention](#) that recommends [the following](#):

"If you are worried about yourself or a friend, talk with a trusted adult. They can help you find the right support, such as going to see a pediatrician, primary care clinician, [school counselors], or mental health professional. They have tools to help. If they ask about thoughts of suicide, it is not to offend or cause harm but to keep you safe. When talking with a professional, be open and honest to be sure they have the information needed to help. Ask questions to make sure you understand and are okay with their suggestions.

Starting a conversation with a friend can be awkward. It's important not to judge or make assumptions. Sharing mental health struggles takes a lot of bravery and vulnerability. Try to be supportive: be there for them, and listen to what they have to say. Pay attention to your own limits when helping friends, and try not to feel bad about needing a break. If you don't take care of yourself, you will not be able to provide emotional support to others."

It's important to know that suicide is the third leading cause of death among teenagers, and about 50% of teen suicides involve a firearm ([American Foundation for Suicide Prevention](#)). Guns make suicide attempts much more likely to be fatal (85-90%). Limiting access to firearms during mental health crises can help save lives. Research shows that when someone can't access their chosen way to commit suicide, most people won't switch to another method in the moment ([Daigle 2005](#)). That's why it's critical to take any warning signs seriously and limit access to lethal methods. Additionally, there are laws to help protect people with mental health crises ([State of California](#)).

If you ever find yourself in this situation, please remember: **you are not responsible for your friend's choices**. Whatever happens, **it is not your fault**. You didn't cause it, and you're not responsible for fixing it alone. Speaking up could save a life—and that's one of the most powerful things you can do for a friend.

Here are additional resources you can use:

- Crisis Text Line: Text TALK to 741741 for free, 24/7 support via text
- 988 Suicide & Crisis Hotline 24/7 Call or text 988 in a mental health crisis or visit 988lifeline.org
- [Never a Bother](#) (California Dept of Health's Office of Suicide Prevention)
- [Safe Storage Protects Children](#) (Wisconsin Office of Children's Mental Health)
- American Foundation for Suicide Prevention:
 - LGBTQ crisis support resources: <https://afsp.org/lgbtq-crisis-and-support-resources/>
 - Risk Factors and warning signs: <https://afsp.org/risk-factors-protective-factors-and-warning-signs/>
- Trans Lifeline Peer support. Call 877-565-8860 or visit translifeline.org
- [HealthyChildren.org](https://www.healthychildren.org) by American Academy of Pediatrics Information on supporting resilience and mental health in families
- Society for the Prevention of Teen Suicide: sptsusa.org